



WC2026 Group Stage Survival Guide

Who goes through? Who goes home? The complete breakdown.

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■ **WC2026 EMPIRE**

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GROUP STAGE FORMAT — 48 TEAMS, 12 GROUPS

3 advance from each group (top 2 guaranteed + 8 best 3rd-place teams)

Group	Teams	Predicted 1st	Predicted 2nd	Dark Horse
A	Mexico, Poland, S.Arabia, Argentina	Argentina	Mexico	Poland
B	USA, England, Iran, Wales	England	USA	Wales
C	France, Australia, Denmark, Tunisia	France	Denmark	Australia
D	Brazil, Serbia, Switzerland, Cameroon	Brazil	Switzerland	Serbia
E	Spain, Costa Rica, Germany, Japan	Spain	Germany	Japan
F	Belgium, Canada, Morocco, Croatia	Belgium	Croatia	Morocco
G	Portugal, Ghana, Uruguay, South Korea	Portugal	Uruguay	S.Korea
H	Senegal, Netherlands, Ecuador, Qatar	Netherlands	Senegal	Ecuador
I	Colombia, Romania, Chile, Ivory Coast	Colombia	Chile	Romania
J	Turkey, New Zealand, Nigeria, Egypt	Turkey	Nigeria	Egypt
K	Algeria, Australia, Japan, South Africa	Algeria	Japan	Australia
L	Iran, Peru, Scotland, Saudi Arabia	Iran	Saudi Arabia	Scotland

THE 3RD PLACE RULE — HOW IT WORKS

8 best 3rd-place teams advance. Ranked by: Points → Goal Diff → Goals Scored → Fair Play
In 2022, all best 3rd-place finishers had 4+ points. In 2026, target 4pts to feel safe advancing.
Historical: 3rd-place teams from strong groups (Europe/S.America) almost always qualify.

MUST-WATCH MATCHES & UPSET ALERTS

Group B

■ MUST WATCH: USA vs England

USMNT host nation vs Three Lions. 4th of July weekend. 85K capacity stadium. Biggest game in USMNT history.

Group A

■ MUST WATCH: Argentina vs Mexico

A rematch of Qatar 2022. Argentina want revenge for their group stage scare. Explosive fixture.

Potential R16

■ MUST WATCH: France vs Germany

If both top their groups (likely), this is the last 16 fixture everyone wants. Euros 2020 vibes.

Group E

■ UPSET ALERT: Japan vs Spain

Japan beat Germany AND Spain in Qatar 2022. History could repeat. Spain are vulnerable to a counter.

Group F

■ UPSET ALERT: Morocco vs Belgium

Morocco eliminated Belgium in 2022. Belgium have an aging squad. Morocco defensively superior.

Group I

■ UPSET ALERT: Colombia vs Romania

Colombia are 18-match unbeaten but Romania can park the bus. Watch for a shock 0-0.

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